

Session 15: The Flood as Cosmic Collapse

Key Takeaways

- The cosmology of the ancient biblical authors—three tiers: waters below, the dry land, and waters above—is crucial to understanding the meaning of the flood.
- The language that's describing the flood is describing neither a local flood nor a global flood. It's describing the collapse of the cosmos—cosmic collapse.
- In the biblical cosmology, the waters above the *raqia'* are still there. God's ongoing, sustaining work of creation is to keep the order of this cosmos from collapsing in chaos.

The Flood Begins and Noah Enters the Ark (Gen. 7:6-16)

The beginning of the flood and Noah's entrance into the ark take place in two parallel panels, each highlighting different features of this part of the story.

Flood Panel #1: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 7:6-10

6 And Noah was six hundred years old , and the flood of waters came upon the land .

a 7 And he went ,
b Noah
c and his sons
b' and his wife
c' and his sons' wives
b' with him
a' into the ark

because of the waters of the flood .

a 8 From the pure animals
a and from the animals that are not pure
b and from the birds
b' and from everything that creeps on the ground,
c 9 two by two they went
to Noah ,
d

d' into the ark ,
c' male and female,
e just as Elohim had commanded Noah.

10 And it came about after the seven days and the waters of the flood were upon the land .

Genesis 7:6-10. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Flood Panel #2: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 7:11-16

11 In the six hundredth year of Noah's life , in the second month,
on the seventeenth day of the month, on that day

- a they were split apart (נבקעו)
 - b all the fountains of the great deep ,
 - b' and the windows of the skies
- a they were opened (נפתחו),
- a 12 and there was rain upon the land
 - b for forty days and forty nights.

13 On that very day

- a he went
 - b Noah
 - c and Shem and Ham and Japheth ,
 - c' the sons of Noah ,
 - b' and Noah's wife
 - c' and the three wives of his sons
 - b' with them,
- a' into the ark .

-
- a' 14 They
 - b and every living creature after its kind,
 - b' and all the beast after their kind,
 - b' and every creeper that creeps on the land after its kind,
 - b' and every bird after its kind,
 - c every bird of every wing.
 - a 15 And they went
 - b to Noah, into the ark,

c two by two,
 d from all flesh in which was the breath of life,
 a' 16 and those going,
 c' were male and female
 d' from all flesh,
 a' they went
 e just as Elohim had commanded him;

and Yahweh closed behind him.

Genesis 7:11-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The Flood as Cosmic Collapse

The Waters Above and Below

The description of the flood uses cosmic imagery that corresponds to Genesis 1, and this makes it clear the flood is also a de-creation story that undoes the order established in Genesis 1.

Genesis 7:11 Instructor's Translation

They were **split apart** (נבקעו)
 all the fountains of the great deep,
 and the windows of the skies
 they were **opened** (נפתחו).

The two water sources correspond exactly to the “waters below” and the “waters above” in Genesis chapter 1.

Genesis 1:2 Instructor's Translation

Now, the land was wild and waste (*tohu va-vohu* / תהו ווהו)
 and darkness was over the face of the deep abyss (*tehom* / תהום),
 but the breath of Elohim was hovering over the face of the waters (*hamayim* / המים).

Genesis 1:6-8 NASB*

Then God said, “Let there be a dome in the midst of the waters, and let it separate **the waters** from the **waters.**” God made the dome, and separated **the waters which were below the dome** from **the waters which were above the dome;** and it was so. God called the dome “heavens/skies.” And there was evening and there was morning, a second day.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

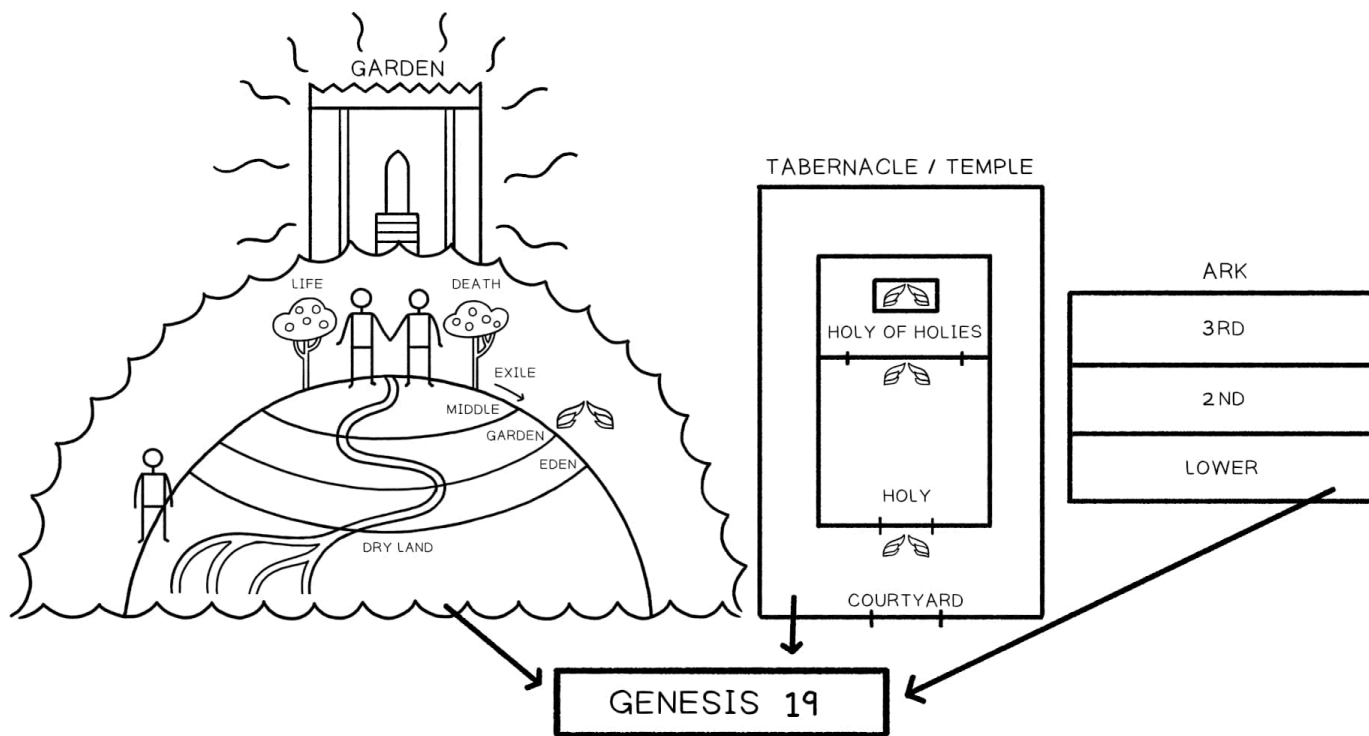
Psalms 104 and 148 are poetic explorations of the cosmology of Genesis 1, summoning every tier of creation and all their inhabitants to praise the creator.

Psalms 104:1-3 NASB

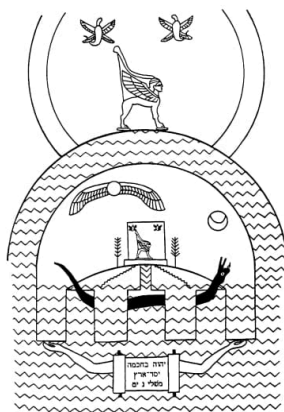
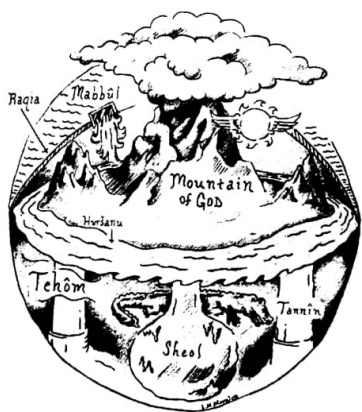
¹ Bless the LORD, O my soul!
O LORD my God, you are very great;
you are clothed with splendor and majesty,
² covering yourself with light as with a cloak,
stretching out heaven like a tent curtain.
³ **He lays the beams of his upper chambers in the waters;**
he makes the clouds his chariot;
he walks upon the wings of the wind.

Psalm 148:1-6 NASB

¹ Praise the LORD!
Praise the LORD from the heavens;
praise him in the heights!
² Praise him, all his angels;
praise him, all his hosts!
³ Praise him, sun and moon;
praise him, all stars of light!
⁴ Praise him, **highest heavens,**
and the waters that are above the heavens!
⁵ Let them praise the name of the LORD,
for he commanded and they were created.
⁶ He has also established them forever and ever;
he has made a decree which will not pass away.



Three-tiered Temple Connections. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).



Left: Morales, L. Michael (2015). *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?: A Biblical Theology of the Book of Leviticus*. IVP Academic. Middle: Keel, Othmar (1997). "Figure 14." *Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns. 161. Right: Walton, John H. (2004). *Old Testament Today: A Journey from Original Meaning to Contemporary Significance*. Zondervan.

When the biblical cosmology is taken into consideration, the flood is a portrait of God's "release" of the order he established in Genesis 1, so that the cosmos collapses in on itself.

"In ... Genesis 1, the reader is introduced to a world in which watery chaos rules supreme until God's intervention brings order ... The flood account in Genesis 6-8 tells the story of how, when the world was corrupted, God withdrew the restraints placed on the waters at the time of creation, and they flooded the world once more from the "great deep" (*tehom rabbah*) and the "windows of the heavens" (*'arubot hashamayim*) ... Thus, the chaos waters by their very nature are symbolic of the absence of order and creation. In the flood narrative, they denote the reversal of creation."

Rudman, Dominic (2001). "Mitteilungen: The Use of Water Imagery in Descriptions of Sheol." *Zeitschrift Für Die Alttestamentliche Wissenschaft*, Volume 113 (2). 240-244.

The Word "Flood"

Our English translation "flood" for the Hebrew word *mabbul* (מבול) is not quite correct. The word *mabbul* is the technical term for the heavenly waters above the sky-dome (see the notes above). The word is used 13 times in the Hebrew Bible, and 12 of them are in Genesis 1-11 as references to the flood.

However, in Psalm 29, *mabbul* is still in the heavens long after the flood, and Yahweh rules over it.

Psalm 29:3, 9-10 NIV*

³ The voice of the LORD **is over the waters**;
the God of glory thunders,
the LORD **is over the great waters**.

⁹ ... in his temple everything says, "Glory!"

¹⁰ The LORD **sits as King of the mabbul**;
yes, the LORD sits as King forever.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"*Mabbul* does not mean 'flood,' 'inundation,' or even 'destruction,' but it is a technical term for a part of the world structure, namely, the heavenly ocean. This heavenly sea, which is above the firmament (*raqia'*), empties downward through latticed windows (Gen. 7:11). Here we have the same realistic and cosmological ideas as in Gen. ch. 1 ... [T]he Flood, therefore, is a catastrophe involving the entire cosmos. When the heavenly ocean breaks forth upon the earth below, and the primeval sea beneath the earth, which is restrained by God, now freed from its bonds, gushes up through yawning chasms onto the earth, then there is a destruction of the entire cosmic system according to biblical cosmogony. The two halves of the chaotic primeval sea, separated—the one up, the other below—by God's creative government (ch. 1:7-9), are again united; creation begins to sink again into chaos. Here the catastrophe, therefore, concerns not only men and beasts ... but the earth (chs. 6:13; 9:11)—indeed, the entire cosmos."

von Rad, Gerhard (1973). [*Genesis: A Commentary*](#) (rev.). Westminster John Knox Press. 128.

Entrance Into the Ark = Entrance Into the New Jerusalem

The Eden/ark/tabernacle/temple parallels make it clear that this narrative is about entering the divinely provided sanctuary to escape the disintegration of creation back into disorder.

- Notice the emphasis on the word "go/went/enter," which all translate the Hebrew word *bo* (בוא).

- This repetition recalls the unique emphasis put upon the “door/entrance” (Heb. *petakh* / פתח), which is the means of entering into the divine refuge.
- It also recalls Noah’s “righteous and blameless” moral character (Gen. 6:9 and 7:1).

This entire collection of themes will be developed later in the Hebrew Bible. Righteous Noah’s entrance into the ark becomes an archetype of David’s desire to take refuge in the temple and of the righteous remnant’s longing to enter the temple on the day of Yahweh.

Psalm 15:1-2 NASB*

¹ O LORD, who may abide in your tent?
Who may tabernacle on your holy hill?
² He who walks with **blamelessness** (*tamim*),
and does what is **right** (*tsedeq*),
and speaks truth in his heart.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 24:1-10 NASB*

¹ The land is Yahweh's, and all it contains,
the world, and those who dwell in it.
² For he has founded it upon the seas
and established it upon the rivers.
³ Who may ascend into the hill of Yahweh?
And who may stand in his holy place?
⁴ He who has clean hands and a **pure heart**,
who has not lifted up his soul to falsehood
and has not sworn deceitfully.
⁵ He shall receive a blessing from the LORD
and **righteousness** from the God of his salvation.
⁶ This is **the generation** of those who seek him,
who seek your face—even Jacob. Selah.
⁷ Lift up your heads, **O doors**,
and be lifted up, **O ancient doors**,
that the King of glory may come in!
⁸ Who is the King of glory?
Yahweh strong and mighty,
Yahweh mighty in battle.
⁹ Lift up your heads, **O doors**,
and lift them up, **O ancient doors**,
that the King of glory may come in!
¹⁰ Who is this King of glory?
Yahweh of armies,
he is the King of glory. Selah.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"The ark/tabernacle parallels extend beyond their construction to the emphasis placed on the conditionality of their being entered. Leviticus 1:3 states that "unblemished" (*tamim*) animals may be presented at the 'entrance' (*petakh*) of the tent of meeting before Yahweh. As the tabernacle/temple is an architectural cosmic mountain, entrance into the holy of holies symbolizes ascent to the summit of God's holy mountain. The question of 'who shall ascend' in Psalm 15 [and Noah's entrance into the ark] is linked to the Day of Atonement."

Morales, Michael (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers. 173.

Isaiah 26:1-4 NASB*

¹ In that day this song will be sung in the land of Judah:

"We have **a strong city**;

he sets up walls and ramparts for security.

² **Open the doors, that the righteous nation may enter, the one that remains faithful.**

³ The steadfast of mind you will keep in perfect peace, because he trusts in you.

⁴ Trust in Yahweh forever, for in God Yahweh, **we have an everlasting rock.**"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 26:20-21 NASB*

²⁰ Come, my people, **enter into your rooms and close your doors behind you;**

hide for a little while

until indignation passes over.

²¹ For behold, Yahweh is about to come out from his place to punish the iniquity of the inhabitants of the land;

and the land will reveal its shed blood, and will no longer cover its slain.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

For more flood allusions, see [Isaiah 24:5-6](#), [17-20](#); [25:3-10](#)

"[In Isaiah chapters 24-27,] Noah as the righteous world citizen par excellence becomes the leadmotif of those who escape the world judgment; the redemption of the righteous from the primeval flood is the paradigm for the redemption of the righteous from final judgment. It is no longer ethnic membership in Israel, but rather ethical behavior that is the measuring rod of salvation ... At the center of the 'strong city' stands the righteous who may enter through its doors. These are Yahweh worshippers from all nations coming to the temple (thus the allusions to the temple entrance liturgies of Psalms 15 and 24). In the same way that Noah, the exemplary righteous person, goes into the ark (Gen. 7:1-6), so the 'righteous nation' marches into the new Jerusalem ... Just as Yahweh closes the door before the waters (Gen. 7:16), so now his people close the doors behind themselves for a little while."

Berges, Ulrich (2012). [*The Book of Isaiah: Its Composition and Final Form*](#). Sheffield Phoenix Press. 175-177.

Reflection Question

To understand the flood story, does it help us to know the cosmology of the biblical authors? If so, how? And what does the flood story have to do with day two of creation in Genesis 1?